

# Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

## Connectors

*There's quite a bit of hype on about CAS, digital TV, and such. With these coming into the picture, TV companies are pushing for better connectivity standards. Things can get pretty blurry with the new lingo they're throwing at you. So go ahead, mug up the following, and you'll sound reasonably intelligent...*

**Composite:** This connectivity standard was the most basic analogue link between a video signal source and a display.

**S-Video:** Better than composite video, because it separates the white level and colour information.

**Y-Pr-Pb:** A standard that was used on most DVD players; they had red, green, and blue colour-coded connectors capable of very high resolutions. However, these are slowly being phased out in favour of digital connectors.

**DVI:** This can either be a digital-only connection or a combination digital and analogue connection capable of high-resolution 8-bit RGB video.

**S/PDIF:** An interface for transferring digital audio from CD and DVD players to, say, amplifiers or TV sets.

**HDMI:** A connectivity standard that features high-resolution digital video and digital audio capabilities, used in many DVD players with upward conversion to HD resolution.

**Usage:** Watching *Rang De Basanti* on my new plasma TV is fantastic, thanks to **HDMI**. Things are now so much better than with the **DVI** or **Y-Pr-Pb** used in older-generation DVD and VHS players! And, of course, **S-Video** and **Composite** are so last decade!

## Wild Wild Web

### The Waste Pipe

It's a little late in the day to be telling you about Google's annual April Fools' joke, but they—like this one—are timeless (in the sense of the link always being there), so here goes. This one isn't timeless in the sense of "priceless": we thought it was more than a tad lame. On The First Day of April appeared a link on the Google homepage leading to a site claiming to offer consumers high-speed wireless Internet service through their home plumbing systems.

The "service" was named "Toilet Internet Service Provider," and there was also a "press release" with statements attributed to Übergoogleer Larry Page. To mention one: "And

today our Toilet ISP team is pleased to be leading the way through the sewers, up out of your toilet and—splat—right onto your PC." Splat?

Then there's a silly picture of a mother with a baby and a commode in the background, with a silly caption to boot: "Want WiFi around? Just flush it down." [www.google.com/tisp](http://www.google.com/tisp) has an installation guide for installing TISP through the sanitation system of a bathroom.

Pigeon Rank was amusing, but this one falls as splat as this silly joke.

### Sniff 'em If You Can...

The tech reporters at the BBC were a little more creative—refer previous item—but only

just. Remember the forward about using your monitor as a webcam? This one didn't go much further than that. "Sniff-Screen Technology," they called it, on April Fools' Day: the "BREAKING NEWS" (the caps were on the BBC homepage) was the launch of that technology, which would let you smell stuff on the screen.

It was a slideshow: a picture of fetid-looking (probably Greek) cheese, roses, and Parisian perfume. Visitors were asked to put their noses close to the screen if they couldn't already smell the aforementioned strong-smelling things.

The thing is archived at <http://tinyurl.com/276c6j>. Show it to your grandmother.

## SPRING CLEANIN

### O'Really?

Can the Web be cleaned up, made more structured, made a better place?

Mid-April, Tim O'Reilly, book publisher and one of the coiners of the term "Web 2.0", and Jimmy Wales, Wikipedia creator, met up and began working on creating guidelines that would make online discussions more civil. One of their recommendations is that bloggers be allowed—without being blamed of censoring things—to delete offensive comments on their blogs. This is just after a rather freakish incident: Kathy Sierra, a technology book author received death threats as comments on her blog. The threats were partly triggered by a dispute over precisely what Wales and O'Reilly are discussing—whether it's OK to delete blog visitor comments. "F\*\*\* off, you boring slut"—or something along those lines—was one of the comments. (Would you feel you had the right to delete such a reply?) This was

followed by stuff about wanting to see a noose around her neck.

Right now, O'Reilly and Mr Wales are talking about segregating blogs into categories, signified by logos. Bloggers who do not want comments would be in one category; tech bloggers who always cite sources (as opposed to writing random, rambling posts) would be in another category, and so forth.

Robert Scoble, technology blogger of Scobleizer fame, said the rules "make (him) feel uncomfortable". He followed with "As a writer, it makes me feel like I live in Iran."

Apparently, they're not talking censorship. To quote O'Reilly: "That is one of the mistakes a lot of people make—believing that uncensored speech is the most free, when in fact, managed civil dialogue is actually the freer speech. Free speech is enhanced by civility."

But this is an overreaction. One woman blogger receives death-threats, and they're talking guidelines for blog behaviour?

Naturally, the words "free speech" come to mind. If it's OK to write what you want on a blog, why not the same principle for replies? Also, we think the proposed idea of "categorisation" will meet with nothing short of hostility.

It's not clear what Wales and O'Reilly are thinking in terms of implementation. The Web cannot be policed, or even "formalised," as it were. Sure we'd all like a cleaner Web, but it's just not happening. Then, forget about blogs and think about forums, and you'll get the drift. Wales cannot properly police his own Wikipedia, and he's talking about slapping rules on the Web...

## ENHANCED REALITY

### Games Like Movies?

There's a little Flash-based game on the Net right now called *Flow In Games* (<http://intihuatani.usc.edu/cloud/flowing/>). Here's what one blogger